there that an activist challenging Vale from Mozambique was denied entrance to Brazil last year to participate in the Rio +20 gathering. He was flown back to Mozambique and only after a global outcry was made, led by Friends of the Earth International, was he allowed to return for the gathering.

Further to this, India also has an interest in Mozambique. The Indian-based Jindal group, which comprises both mining and smelting, set their eyes on Mozambican coal in Moatize, as well as having advanced plans for a coal-fired power station in Mozambique, again to create supply for the demanding elite-driven economy of South Africa.

Russia also plays an interesting role in Mozambique. While not much is known about the Russian state and corporate involvement, following the break-up when the Soviet Union collapsed, there is a link with Russia's Eurasian Natural Resources Corporation which has non-ferrous metal operations in Mozambique. Interestingly, the Russian government has just invested R1.3 billion in Mozambique to facilitate skills development to actively exploit hydrocarbons and other natural resources, according to Russian Foreign Minister Sergei Lavrov.

So this tells a tale of one country, in which tens of billions of rands of investment by BRICS countries and companies result in the extraction of wealth. Mozambique will join the resource-cursed societies of our region, with polluted local environments, and a changed structure of people's lives, making them dependent on foreign decisions rather than their own local and national political power. This is not a random set of exploitations, but rather a well-orchestrated strategy to shift the elite development agenda away from Europe, the US and Japan, to what we now term the BRICS.

This positioning means that the BRICS' drive for economic superiority is pursued in the name of poverty alleviation. No matter how one terms the process – imperialist, sub-imperialist, post-colonial, or whatever – the reality is that these countries are challenging the power relations in the world, but sadly the model chosen to challenge this power is nothing different from the model that has resulted in mass poverty and elite wealth globally.

This is the model of extraction and extreme capital-intensive development based upon burning and exploiting carbon, and of elite accumulation through structural adjustment, also termed the Washington Consensus. The agenda of setting up the BRICS Bank is a case in point: it is opaque and not open to public scrutiny. Except for the reality as presented above, these countries are coming together with their corporate powers to decide who gets what and where in the hinterland of Africa, Latin America, Asia and the Caucasus.

It is projected that by 2050, BRICS countries will be in the top ten economies